DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Is One Person Born Rich and Another Poor?

Derech Hashem 2:3:1-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraphs 1-3, with a preview of paragraph 4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 13 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new chapter: personal providence

On Monday the class learned that reaching the World to Come does not mean every misvah you did is a "World to Come misvah"; many may be repaid in this world. Now the Ramhal begins Part 2, Chapter 3, on hashgahah ishit, personal providence. "This is a very interesting chapter."

Paragraph 1: different situations, different tests

Our service in this world is to choose good over bad, and there are many individual kinds of each. Arrogance is bad and humility good; mercy is good and cruelty bad; being satisfied with what you have is good, and always wanting more is bad. Hashem took into account the whole human race and all these traits, with the goal that people can choose between good and bad.

But for these traits to exist, there must be different situations among people. If there were no rich and poor, a person could not be tested on whether he will be merciful or cruel. Now that there are, the rich man is tested by his wealth: will he be cruel, or have mercy on the poor? The poor man is tested: will he be content with what he has and thank Hashem, or will he complain? The rich man has another test: will his wealth make him arrogant and draw him after the vanities of this world until he forgets Hashem, or will he remain humble despite it all?

"If everyone was the same, if communism and socialism was to be in charge, then what? How would you be kind? How would you give charity?" The same applies to health: some are healthy, some are not, and the healthy are tested on whether they help.

But why me? A participant asked: what determines that I am born wealthy and he is born poor? The Rabbi said there is no answer to that. There has to be a difference, but why this person has this test, "I can't tell you." (He asked that gilgulim, reincarnation, be left aside for now, since the chapter comes to it later; here we speak of a fresh start.) What we can say is that every circumstance is taken into account: for one person, not becoming arrogant may be a harder test than, for another, not complaining.

The Ramhal goes on to say this directly. Hashem, in His deep counsel, divided the tests among people, and each person has his own unique and designated role in life. Whatever you have been given, health, wealth, wisdom, appearance, "that's your bag you need to deal with." And each person will be judged on all of it according to what he was given, with exact precision.

The king's servants

The Ramhal's analogy: a king's servants all serve to carry out his wishes, but their roles differ. One makes the king's tea; another takes out the rubbish. Is the tea-maker more important? No, they simply have different roles, and between them the king's wishes are fulfilled. What you need to worry about is your own portion. The man taking out the bin should not ask why he does not have the other job, nor should the tea-maker envy the other, who does not have to dress up to be in the king's presence every day. "This is what you've been given. You deal with it." And the king rewards each according to his portion.

The Ramhal adds that why Hashem assigned roles as He did is too lofty for our understanding. Each role has its own advantages and burdens, and all of it is weighed. Algorithms and computers are starting to help us grasp how countless variables can be calculated, and every one of our millions of tests will be weighed with every variable in the final judgment: health, wisdom, position, wealth. "You cannot cherry pick." That is why "you are haughty if you think you can judge someone."

A participant observed that the overriding test, whatever role you are given, is whether you are satisfied with it. The Rabbi agreed: "Get on with your own job. Don't worry about what other guys are doing."

Do not covet

If we lived with this idea, he said, we would be happier and more content. He pointed to the verse to be read on Shavuot: "Do not covet your neighbour's wife, his servant, his maidservant... or anything that is your neighbour's." The problem with jealousy is that you cherry-pick the good things someone has and forget his troubles. "No one's got the perfect life." You admire one man's car, but you do not know he fights with his wife every day; another has a wonderful wife, but suffers in his health. "Anything that is your neighbour's" means you must take the whole package, so look instead at your own role. "In theory we understand this. In application, do we live like this? That's a different question."

Paragraph 2: it all starts above

The Rabbi said he was not fully clear why the Ramhal needs this paragraph, since it repeats an earlier principle: everything in this world, wealth or poverty, health or illness, has its source in the higher realms and comes down through a chain until it manifests in physical reality, and Hashem watches over it all. "Your situation in this world... is preordained," and its origin is above.

Paragraph 3: a second answer to the old question

From this root, the Ramhal says, a person's successes and difficulties in this world can be the test Hashem decided is fitting for him.

The Rabbi tied this to the question raised the week before: why do the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper? The first answer, from Chapter 2, was cleansing: the saddik suffers to wash away his bit of bad, and the rasha prospers so his bit of good is repaid. This is the second: the saddik may be suffering not because anything is wrong, but because this is his role. "He is the garbage collector of the king." The other man was made wealthy as his test, whether he is a saddik or a rasha. The Rabbi called this "three quarters" of an explanation, since why one gets the test of wealth and another the test of poverty we cannot know.

A preview of paragraph 4: the path you choose

The Rabbi previewed a third answer, to be studied in the next class. You have been given your role, and sometimes you are given extra means to help you fulfil it. Hashem sees that a person's heart truly wants to do good, for example he has developed a deeply charitable heart, but lacks the means, and Hashem may give him wealth. This differs from the first case: he was born ordinary and grew into it.

The same applies in the opposite direction. A rasha has terrible plans. Sometimes Hashem intervenes and does not let him obtain the weapon, because He still sees potential in him; and sometimes He provides the means and lets him go down the path he has chosen. How and why, "I've got no idea," but that is the general principle.

A participant connected this to Pharaoh, and the Rabbi agreed: this is how the famous question of Pharaoh's free will in the later plagues is answered. "The path you want to go, we provide to you." If you are set on a good path, you will be helped along it too. "You need to direct yourself."

Summary

- Differences of wealth, health and circumstance exist so that each trait, mercy or cruelty, contentment or complaint, humility or arrogance, can be tested.
- Each person has a unique role and will be judged precisely according to what he was given; why he received it is beyond us.
- Like servants of a king, we should attend to our own task, not envy others, whose full situation we never see.
- A second answer to why the righteous suffer: it may simply be their role and test, not a punishment.
- A third answer, previewed: Hashem gives people the means to follow the path they have chosen, for good or bad.

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